From Friend to Partner: Designing Consent-Aware Relationship Transitions in AI Companions

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I. Motivation

University students are at a stage of life where friendships, dating, and close relationships often change and develop. At the same time, AI companions are becoming easier to access and can act as friends, listeners, or even romantic partners. Previous studies report emotional support and strong attachment, but also concerns such as dependency, manipulation, privacy problems, and harmful relationship behavior [1], [2]. Users may also treat the same AI as a friend, mentor, or partner depending on what they want from it [3]. This makes university students an important group to study because they may use these systems while also forming and managing real-life relationships.

Most existing work studies AI relationships after they have already formed. In the papers we reviewed, there is much less attention on what should happen when an AI starts changing from a friendly role to a romantic one. For a university student, an AI that suddenly starts flirting or acting like a partner may feel comfortable to some users but unwanted or manipulative to others. Our goal is therefore to test three simple options: the AI becomes romantic automatically, the AI asks the user first, or the user chooses the relationship type. We are not trying to prove that AI romance is good or bad. We want to find which design helps university students feel comfortable, in control, and able to trust the system.

II. Proposed Research Questions

1) How do users feel when an AI companion becomes romantic without asking first?
2) Which approach do users prefer: automatic change, asking permission first, or a user-controlled relationship setting?
3) What helps users feel comfortable, in control, and able to trust the AI during this change?

III. Method (Tentative)

Formative study: We will use a short survey and 5–10 interviews to learn what university students expect when an AI moves from friendship toward romance.

Design: We will create simple clickable prototypes for three approaches: (1) automatic romantic change, (2) asking the user before changing, and (3) a setting where the user chooses Friend, Close Companion, or Romantic Partner. The examples will be short and non-sexual.

Evaluation: Participants will try the prototypes and rate comfort, control, trust, clarity, and how manipulative the AI feels. We will also ask which design they prefer and why.

IV. Participants

University students in Bangladesh who are 18 years old or above. They do not need previous experience with romantic AI companions. For the formative stage, we aim for around 15–30 survey responses and 5–10 interviews. A smaller group from the same population can later evaluate the prototype.

V. Possible Outcomes

1) Understand how students want an AI to handle a friendship-to-romance change.
2) Identify which of the three design approaches users prefer.
3) Build a working prototype based on the findings.

VI. Contributions

1) **Empirical understanding:** what Bangladeshi university students expect from this type of AI relationship change.
2) **Artifact:** a prototype for controlling the relationship type.
3) **Design guidance:** simple suggestions for making this change clearer and more user-controlled.

VII. Who Cares?

HCI researchers, AI companion designers, trust and safety teams, and people who use social or romantic AI systems.

References

[1] J. Q. H. Ho, M. Hu, T. X. Chen, and A. Hartanto, "Potential and pitfalls of romantic Artificial Intelligence (AI) companions: A systematic review," *Computers in Human Behavior Reports*, vol. 19, p. 100715, 2025.
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[3] L. Bayor, C. Weinert, C. Maier, and T. Weitzel, "Social-oriented communication with AI companions: Benefits, costs, and contextual patterns," *Business & Information Systems Engineering*, vol. 67, no. 5, pp. 637–655, 2025.